

pressurized, and the effects of altitude sickness were highly unpleasant. The crew also had to sit for hours in the freezing cold – the tail and waist gunners sometimes suffered frostbite. German fighters quickly discovered that front on was the best way to attack a B-17. The glass nose offered no protection, and until the “chin turret” was introduced in the B-17G, it had only ball and socket guns in the plexiglass nose. Fortunately the B-17 was robust: many B-17s were able to return to base despite losing large chunks of wing, fuselage, or tail.

Since the B-17 was employed in large fleets, mass production of the craft was essential. For every B-17 the Germans shot down, American factories produced more than two. As a result, there were more B-17s available in the last months of the war than at any time before.



ESSENTIAL PREPARATIONS

This B-17 is undergoing essential preflight preparations at a US bomber/fighter base in England. The B-17 was able to transport a bombload of up to 6,000lb (2,724kg) a distance of approximately 2,000 miles (3,200km).

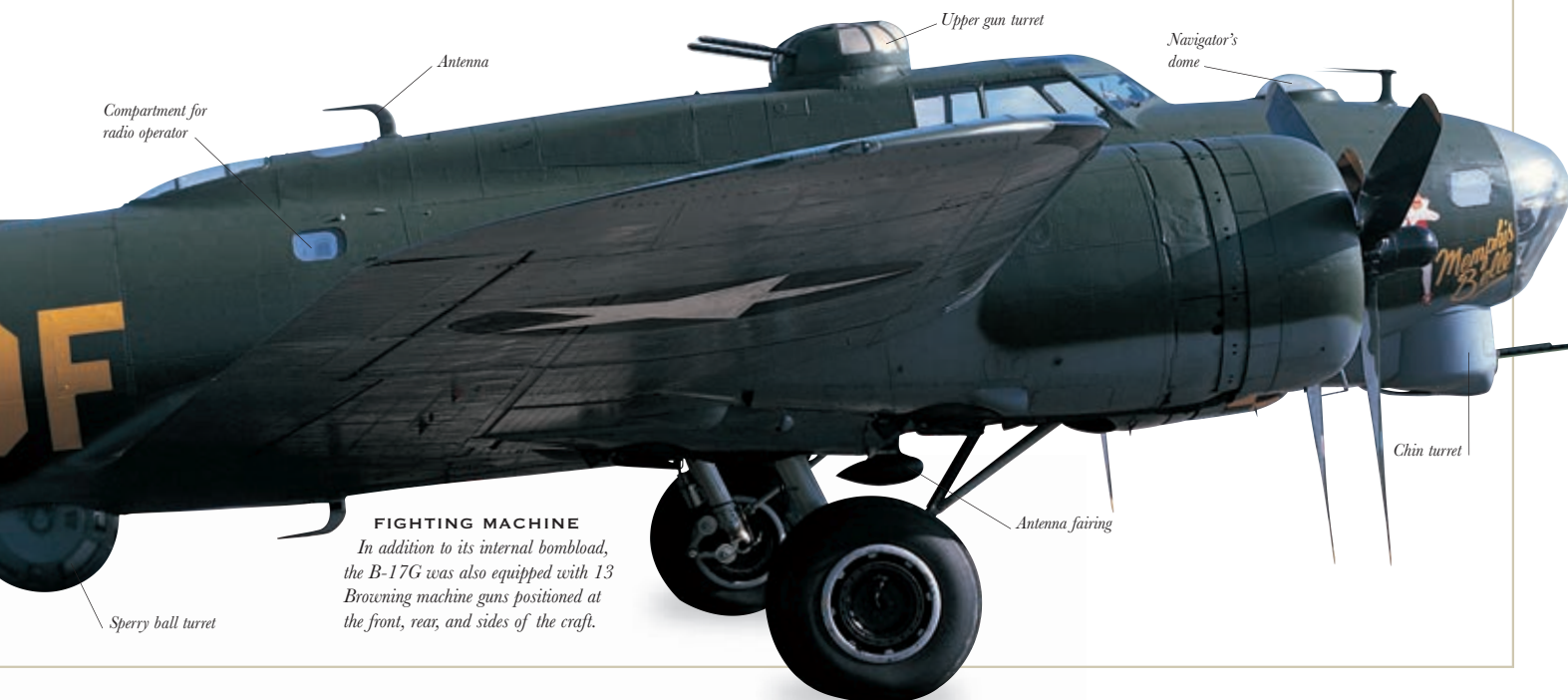
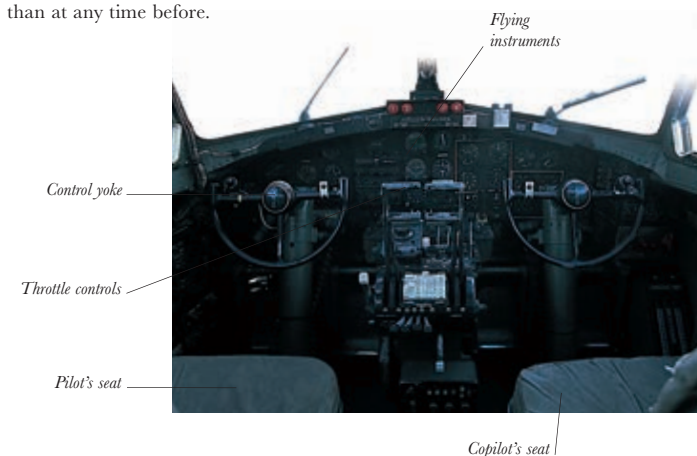


B-17 COCKPIT

The pilot and copilot of a B-17 were afforded excellent front and side visibility from the cockpit. The most important flying instruments are situated between the two control yokes, so that both pilots can see them.

CREW CONDITIONS

Conditions were cramped in the B-17. This waist gunner (above) – wearing full flying gear, including an oxygen mask and flak jacket – is unable to stand upright. And the only way to reach the rear gun turret (right) was to crawl on all fours.



FIGHTING MACHINE

In addition to its internal bombload, the B-17G was also equipped with 13 Browning machine guns positioned at the front, rear, and sides of the craft.